Country Profile: Republic of Korea

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 2
- Plurality religion: Christianity; Buddhism
- Official language: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Koreans

Historical Background

The Republic of Korea was established on the southern half of the Korean peninsula in 1948, claiming, as much as its northern counterpart, to be the legitimate government of the entire Korean state and territory. The Korean war, one of the first major proxy wars of the Cold War, took place between 1950 and 1953, ending with an armistice but no reconciliation between the parties. A phase of authoritarian rule in South Korea was ended in 1987, and the Republic has continued as a democracy since then.

Groups

- **Koreans** are the largest group and, with its members dominating politics and the economy, and with the state imparting signifiers of its identity, the core group of Korea. They comprise approximately 98% of the state's population.[1] They speak Korean and approximately one-third of the group's members are non-religious, another third adhere to the Christian faith, and one-fifth practice Buddhism, historically associated with the group.[2]
- **Chinese** first arrived in Korea during the early Joseon dynasty (1392–1910), but their numbers remained relatively small for several centuries. A more significant influx occurred in the 20th century, especially between 1910 and 1945 during the period of Japanese colonial rule. Migration increased again in the 1980s and 1990s. Today, Chinese are the largest minority in the country,[3] comprising around

[1] Minority Rights, 2024.
[2] CIA World Fact Book, 2025.
[3] Nam, 2013.

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This project has received funding from the European Research Council (ERC) under the European Union's Horizon 2020 research and innovation programme (grant agreement No 864333).

2% of the population.[4] Members of the group traditionally speak Mandarin Chinese, although Korean is now also widely used.[5] Religiously, the absolute majority are non-religious, and around one-fifth uphold traditional Shenist beliefs.[6]

State Profile

Official Language

The constitution does not establish an official language. The status of Korean as an official language is established by Article 3 of the 2005 Framework Act on the Korean language.[7]

Official Religion

The constitution does not recognize an official religion. Article 12 of the 1948 Constitution states that "no state religion shall exist."

Education Policies

Education is compulsory for children from the age of six, starting with elementary school, *chodeung-hakgyo*, which comprises grades one to six. This is followed by middle school (lower secondary), spanning three years. Secondary education is completed after an additional three years spent in high schools (higher secondary) or, alternatively, in more practically oriented vocational schools.[8]

Language Education Policies

Korean has been used as the language of instruction in South Korean public primary and secondary schools since the establishment of the state. Chinese was introduced as an optional language class in secondary schools in 1955.[9] In 2016, bans on English-language education were imposed under the pretext of ensuring children's development of Korean language proficiency.[10] Private schools, which are required to follow the Ministry of

[4] Minority Rights, 2024.
[5] Choi, 2001.
[6] Joshua Project, 2025.
[7] Framework Act on Korean Language, 2005.
[8] Scholaro, 2025.
[9] Jeon, 2019.
[10] Jeon, 2019; Ghani, 2018.

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Education's curriculum, are equally required to provide teaching in Korean while having the option to provide Chinese language classes.

Religious Education Policies

The Education Act of South Korea stipulates that public schools must not "conduct religious education in favor of any particular religion."[11] As such, only balanced religious education is permitted, and no faith is imparted through Korean public schools. Private schools are free to teach religious classes, and private schools established by religious communities make up around 10% of the middle and high schools in Korea.[12]

Constitutions and Laws

The constitution of Korea was promulgated in 1948 and, save some revisions, has largely remained in force since. No ethnic groups are explicitly mentioned in its text, and no language is constitutionally recognized as the official language of the state. While not explicitly establishing the state as secular, the constitution recognizes universal religious liberties and the separation of church and state.[13]

Citizenship Laws

Under Article 2 of South Korea's Nationality Act of 1948, citizenship is primarily acquired by descent (*jus sanguinis*). In cases where both parents are unknown or stateless, a child born in South Korea is granted citizenship by birth. Additionally, an abandoned child found in South Korea is presumed to have been born there and is likewise granted citizenship.[14] No group has actively been excluded from citizenship.

National Anthem(s)

One national anthem has been in use since the establishment of the Republic of Korea, adopted in 1948. Available in the Korean language only, the lyrics make references to the national territory, such as "the waters of the East Sea" and "Mount Baekdusan," and to Korean nationhood.

[11] Art. 6(2).
[12] Kim, 2013.
[13] Constitution of the Republic of Korea, Art. 12.
[14] Nationality Act, 1948.

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